study shows that not only were these two issues high on the list of voter concerns but more than 50 per cent of the respondents also said that their economic condition had either remained the same or worsened in the past year. The findings were akin to the conclusions in the INDIA TODAY Mood of the Nation survey in February 2024. Despite the BJP painting it as a ploy to rob Hindu women of their *mangalsutras* to give them to Muslims, Rahul's call for a redistribution of wealth from the rich to the poor seemed to have had some resonance, as perhaps did

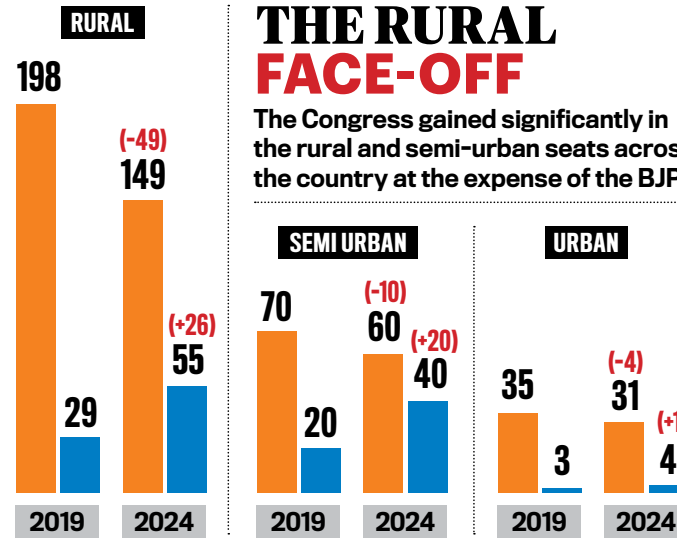
Modi's challenges may now come from within the party itself, which may call for an end to the overcentralised decision-making and the my-way-or-the-highway approach

the welfare guarantees listed in the Congress manifesto, including the Rs 1 lakh a year promised to every woman in a poor household as part of its commitment to Mahila Nyay. An internal study by India Today TV shows that the BJP lost as many as 49 of the 198 rural seats it won in 2019, while the Congress added 26 rural seats to its tally of 29 from the previous election. In semi-urban areas too, the BJP lost 10 of the 70 seats it won in 2019 while the Congress gained as many as 20 seats, taking its tally up to 40 this election.

What the BJP will take comfort in is their creditable win in Odisha, as it secured 20 out of the 21 seats in the Lok Sabha and a simple majority for the first time in the assembly election held simultaneously. Also its expansion of seats in Andhra Pradesh, where it tied up with the Telugu Desam Party as its junior partner and benefited from the landslide victory former chief minister Chandrababu Naidu pulled off in the assembly election that was also held at the same time. The BJP also retained its fortresses in Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh, while making modest gains in Telangana and scoring a major psychological victory with a seat in Kerala for the first time ever. But these gains proved scarce consolation for the blow it received in the swing states of Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra, West Bengal and Bihar, which together account for 210 seats in the Lok Sabha. The BJP tally in these four states plummeted to 66 seats from the 120 it won on its own in the previous election, an attrition of 54 seats. The party posted losses in Rajasthan, Haryana, Karnataka and Jharkhand as well.

THE RURAL FACE-OFF

The Congress gained significantly in the rural and semi-urban seats across the country at the expense of the BJP

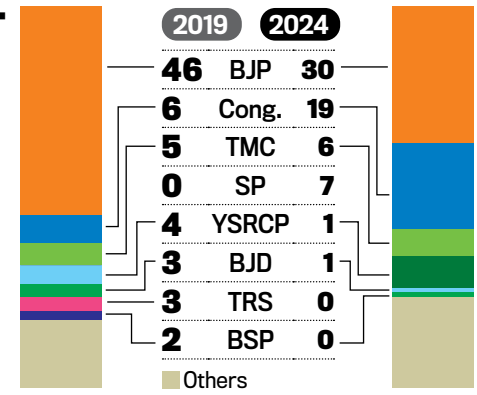


Source: Data Intelligence Unit, India Today

THE DALIT FACTOR

The Congress and its allies also made significant gains in the seats reserved for the Scheduled Castes

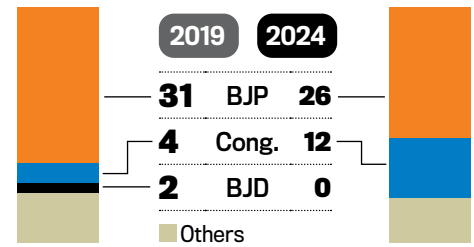
Total SC seats: **84**



TRIBAL BALLOT

A similar story played out in the constituencies reserved for the Scheduled Tribes

Total ST seats: **47**



THE RAM PLATEAU

The cruellest cut came from UP, a BJP bastion that had given it 62 of its 80 seats in 2019, and another two to ally Apna Dal (S). That tally now stands reduced to a mere 33 for the BJP, 29 less than last time, and 36 for the NDA, less than half the total seats in the state. This despite UP being under the rule of another BJP strongman, chief minister Yogi Adityanath, re-elected by a handsome majority in the 2022 assembly polls. The BJP's hope of a wave around the